UX RESEARCH · CASE STUDY

Nineteen features, seven people, one buildable first release

A demo, a Kano survey and an interview, used to turn an unresolvable scoping argument into an evidence backed roadmap



19 features in the prototype · Keap, a Thryv product · March 2024 · Jang Soo Lim

Two products doing the same job

Keap Ultimate customers used Opportunities. Pro and Max customers used Pipelines. One company maintaining both, and a migration path nobody was taking because the existing pipeline had limitations that made switching feel like a downgrade.

What I was asked

- Does the new pipeline design actually meet the needs of Keap partners and customers?
- Would an Opportunities user hit a wall if they moved across to it?

The question underneath

- Nineteen features was not a first release. Engineering could not carry it and the timeline would not hold it.
- So somebody was going to decide what shipped first, and without evidence that decision goes to whoever argues most persuasively.

The failure mode I wanted to rule out was specific. **An MVP missing something users consider basic does not read as incomplete. It reads as broken.**

One session, three parts

1 Structured demo

Jake Ferguson walked each participant through all nineteen features in the new design, so everyone met the same capability set before being asked about any of it.

2 Kano survey

All nineteen features, each asked twice: how would you feel if this were present, and how would you feel if it were absent. Thirty eight paired questions in one sitting.

3 Interview

Open discussion of the design, closing with a free choice of the three features each participant most wanted. That choice became an independent check on the survey.

7

participants, each taking part in a single session

6 + 1

six Keap partners and one Keap Ultimate customer

19

features in the prototype, every one of them in scope

Why a demo rather than a task based test

Walk me through adding a deal

Pipeline usage differs enormously from business to business. A consultancy with four long deals a quarter and an agency with two hundred short ones use the same screen in almost unrelated ways. A task based study has to pick flows, and picking them decides in advance which use is the real one.

Here is everything the new design can do

The same exposure to the same capability set for every participant, without forcing anyone into a single way of working. That exposure was the precondition for the rest of the session, and it let me ask about all nineteen features rather than the three a task set would have reached.

The trade is real and I said so in the readout

A demo tells you what people think of a capability described and shown to them.

It does not tell you whether they can use it. I was buying breadth across nineteen features and across highly varied use, and paying for it in depth on any one of them.

Why Kano rather than a ranking

Rate these 19 features by importance

People rate almost everything as important, and the things they rate highest are often the things they would never notice were working. A simple importance survey would have told us nineteen features were all quite important, which is the argument we were already having.

How would you feel if it were there? And if it were not?

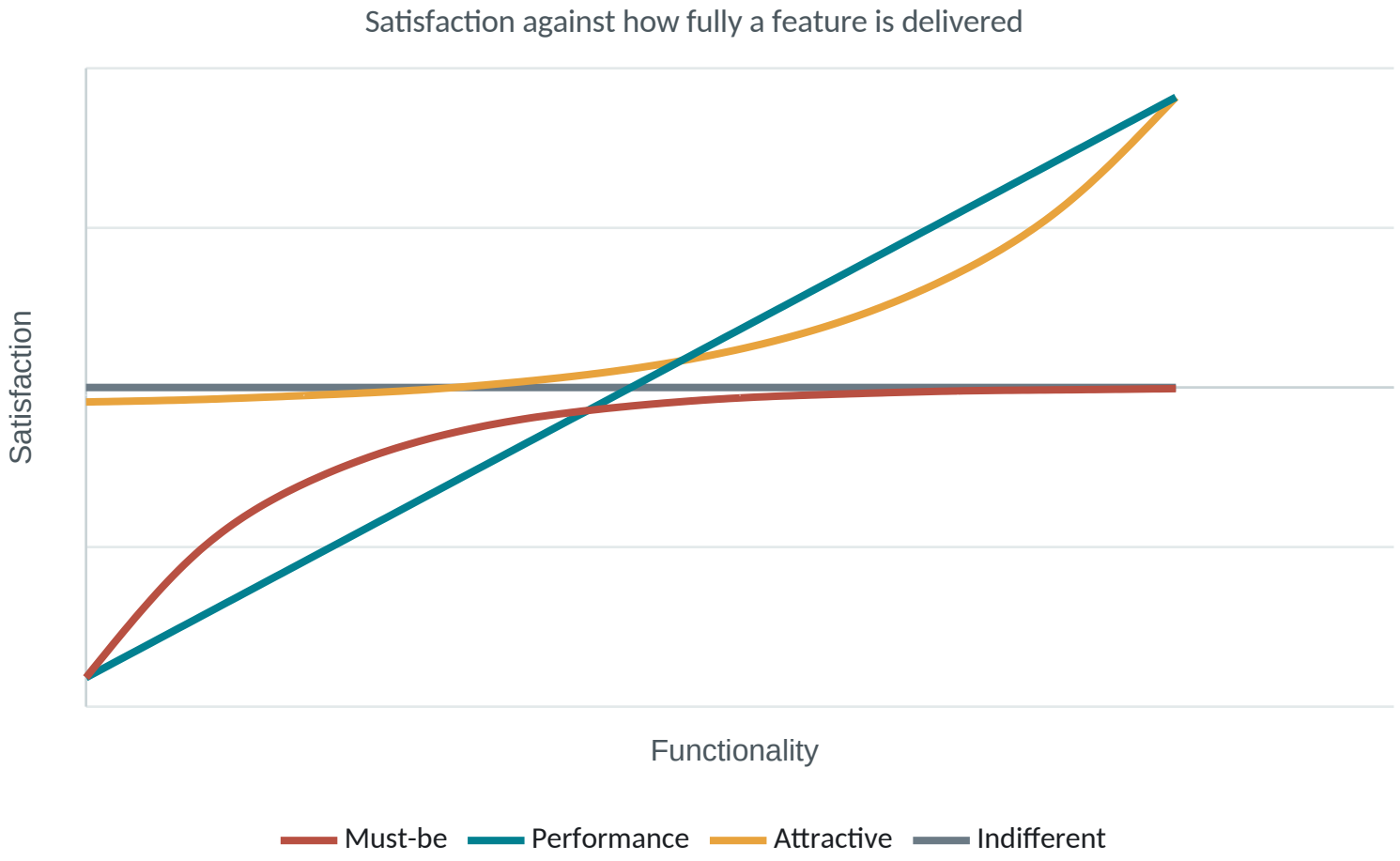
Asking twice, functionally and dysfunctionally, reveals the shape of a person's relationship with the feature rather than just its weight. That shape is what sorts a feature into a category.

Categorical is what a scoping conversation needs

“Rank these nineteen” does not tell you where the line goes.

“These are the price of entry, these scale with investment, these would delight, these are noise” does.

The model, in one picture



Must-be

No satisfaction when present, real frustration when absent. The price of entry.

Performance

Scales. More of it, or a better version of it, produces proportionally more satisfaction.

Attractive

Delights when present, not missed when absent. A differentiator, not an obligation.

Indifferent

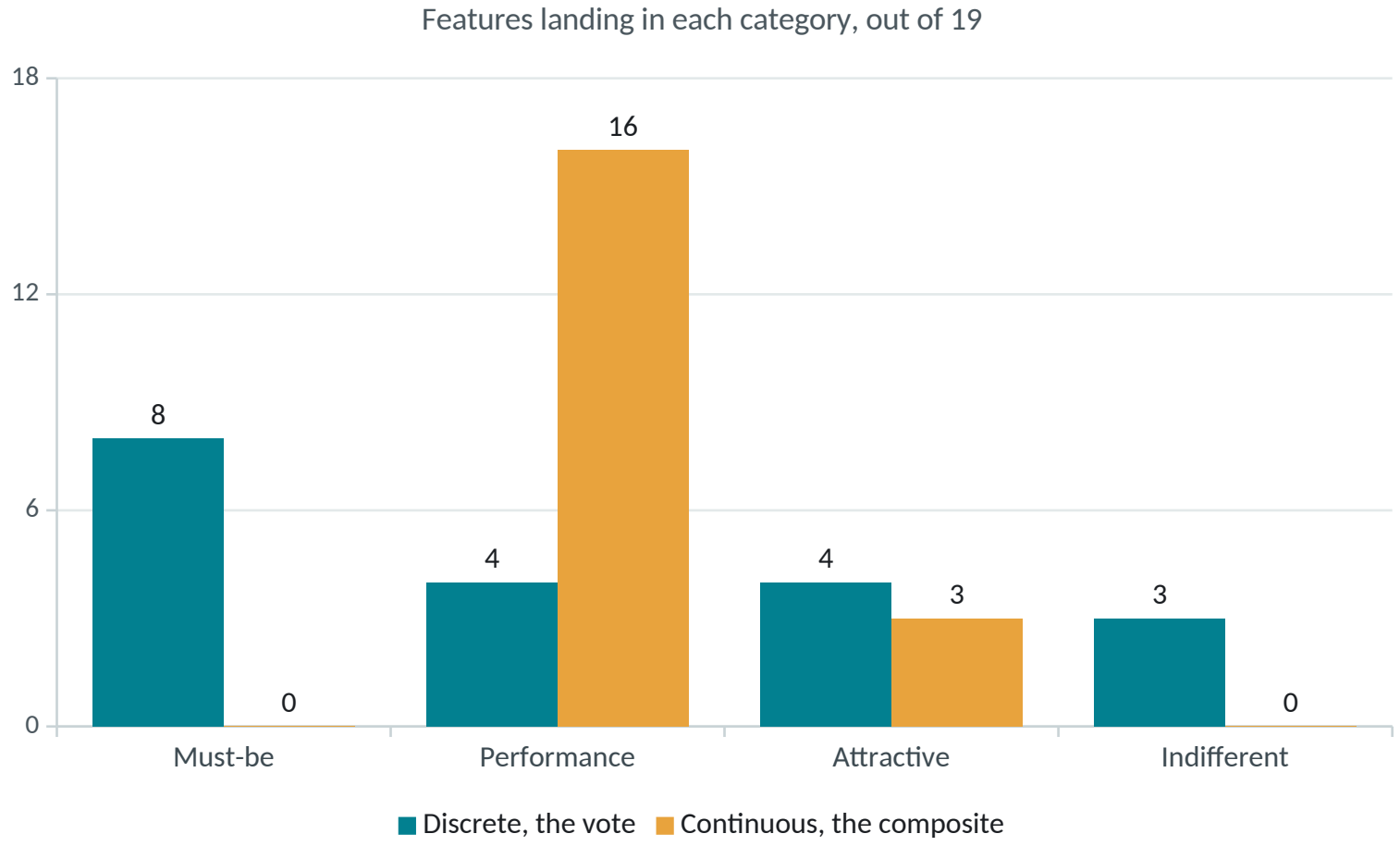
Moves the user in neither direction. The cheapest thing on the list to cut.

THE ANALYTICAL CHOICE

Running both analyses instead of picking one

A Kano dataset can be read two ways and most studies pick one. With seven participants, the disagreement between the two readings is itself information.

The two readings told different stories



Discrete

Classify each participant's response, then take the mode. A feature's category is whatever the largest group of individuals said.

Continuous

Average the underlying ratings first, then classify the average. It describes the group as a composite rather than as a vote.

The gap is not a contradiction

It is a property of averaging. Averaging pulls everything toward the middle of the grid, and the middle of the Kano grid is Performance.

So I combined them

Each analysis contributed a weight on the model's own order of importance, and a feature's score was the sum of its two weights.

Must-be
weight 4

Performance
weight 3

Attractive
weight 2

Indifferent
weight 1

A score of 7 is the strongest signal available

Called Must-be by the vote and Performance by the composite. Both readings agree it is close to the price of entry.

A score of 3 is the weakest

Called Indifferent by one reading and Attractive by the other. Nothing in the data argues for building it first.

The scores sorted cleanly into tiers, which is not something I could have promised in advance.

Nineteen features, three tiers

P0 · scored 7 · 8 features

- Organizing multiple pipelines
- Customising the display by user role
- Viewing basic stats per pipeline
- Sorting and filtering lists
- Seeing the contact record without leaving the deal
- Seeing custom fields in the deal view
- Viewing and editing general settings
- Seeing the automations connected to each pipeline

P1 · scored 6 · 4 features

- Toggling between board, list and analytics views
- Performing bulk actions
- Viewing analytics
- Changing the board card layout

P2 or cut · scored 5 or below

The remaining seven. An evidenced “users did not respond to this” is far easier to accept than a colleague's opinion that something is not worth building.

The four ties I did not average away

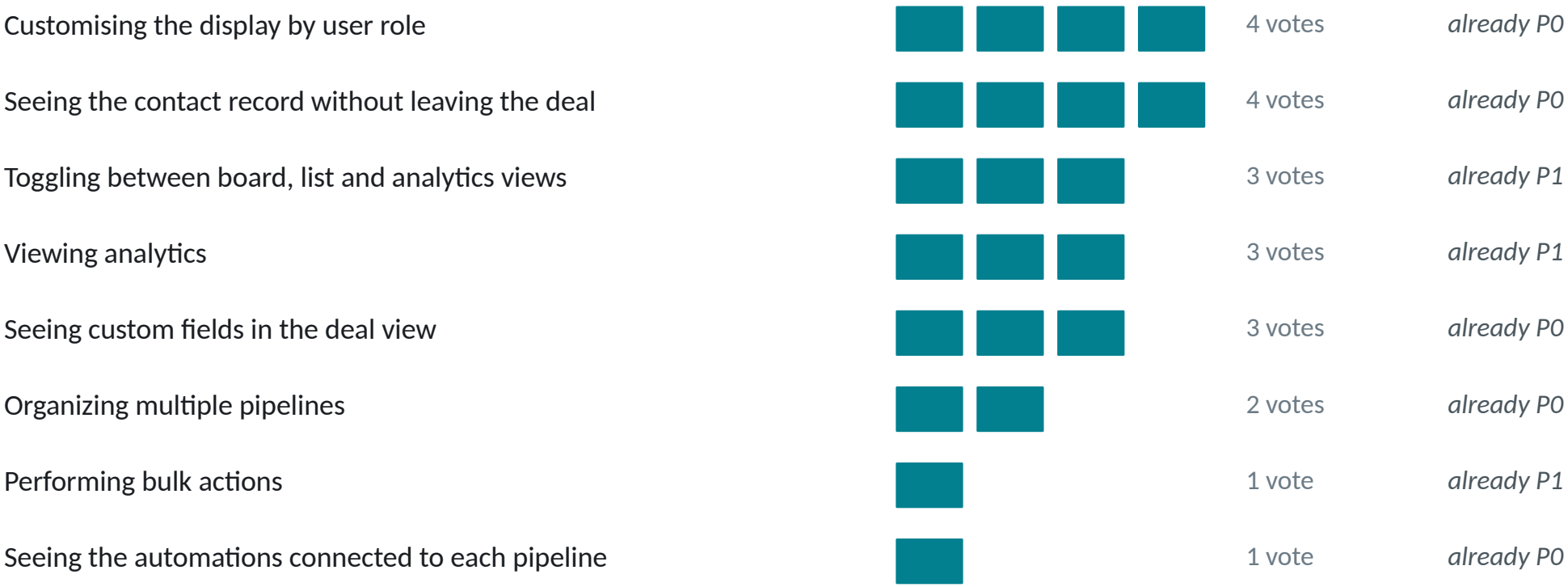
Four features came back with tied modes in the discrete analysis, where two categories drew the same share of participants.

Toggling between board, list and analytics views	**Performance**	*tied with*	**Attractive**
Changing the board card layout	**Performance**	*tied with*	**Attractive**
Seeing the contact record without leaving the deal	**Must-be**	*tied with*	**Attractive**
Viewing and editing general settings	**Must-be**	*tied with*	**Attractive**

With seven participants a tie means three people said one thing and three said another. Any rule I invented to break it would have been my judgment dressed as arithmetic, so I flagged all four as unresolved and named them as the ones to watch.

The interview agreed with the instrument

Part 3 closed with an independent check: after the demo and the survey, each participant freely picked the three features they most wanted.



Every feature named in the vote had already landed in P0 or P1 on the weighted score. A structured instrument whose logic participants cannot see, and an open choice in their own words, pointing at the same features.

What the interviews surfaced that the survey could not

Participants were consistent that the new pipeline was a superior model to the old one, that the features looked genuinely useful, and that they wanted them in the current product rather than at some point in the future. Then they named four gaps.

1

Third party connections

Whether the new pipeline would connect to the other platforms their businesses already run on.

2

Next action dates

Missing entirely from the prototype, and central to how several participants work a deal.

3

Won and lost reasons

No clear way to record why a deal closed the way it did, which is the data a pipeline exists to produce.

4

Product and service monitoring

Visibility into which products and services clients were actually buying.

None of the four were among the nineteen. A prioritization study tells you how to order the list you brought. It does not tell you what is missing from it. The interview did.

What it changed

The first release was scoped on the P0 tier and shipped behind a feature flag. A selected group of clients got the flag turned on, so the team could watch real use before a wider release, with P1 and P2 following.

1

The argument changed shape

Before the study the team argued about features. Afterwards they argued about the evidence, which is a more productive argument because it has a resolution procedure. A position could still be challenged, but challenging it meant engaging with what partners and customers had said.

2

Cutting became possible

Removing scope is the hardest act in product work because every feature has an author, and “we are not building this” lands as a verdict on the person who proposed it. An external classification depersonalises that.



Eight in the first release, four behind it, seven below the line. Every square now has a reason attached.

The limitations I put in the deck

Seven people, not a rate

One participant is 14.29 percent. A category was frequently decided by three people. I reported the percentages because they are what the method produces, and said plainly they should be read as seven people.

Expert proxies, not users

Six of the seven were Keap partners. They see many businesses and know the product deeply, which is why they were recruited. It also means a partner's read on what a small business needs is secondhand.

Stated, on a prototype

Kano is a stated preference method and here it ran against a demo. This tells you what users expect of a pipeline like this one. It does not tell you whether our implementation lands.

Nineteen features is a long instrument

Far more than the handful Kano guidance recommends, because every feature costs two near duplicate questions. I ran nineteen deliberately, because scoping is a question about the whole set and a result about three would have left sixteen to argument. The cost was a real fatigue risk I could not design out.

Categories decay

What is Attractive this year becomes Performance as competitors adopt it, and Must-be once users stop noticing it was ever a choice. The classification is a snapshot of a market at a moment, and I handed it over labelled that way.

What I would do differently

1

Recruit end customers, analyzed separately

One Ultimate customer against six partners cannot support that split. Migrating Opportunities users was the strategic point of the exercise, and their voice is the one the sample was thinnest on.

2

Plan the tie break before fielding

With a sample this size, tied modes are predictable rather than surprising. A rule agreed in advance is defensible in a way that a decision made after seeing the result is not.

3

Get effort estimates first

Engineering's estimates arrived after the analysis. Knowing which features were expensive would have told me which classifications deserved the most analytical care.

4

Pilot the feature descriptions

I wrote them as plain statements of the outcome and had colleagues read them for leading language, but never tested them. On a study where the instrument is nineteen descriptions, they deserve their own round.

Build the re-test into the handover. I said categories decay and then let it sit there. Once the flagged release was live there was a real opportunity to check the predictions against behavior, to see whether the Must-be features were invisible when working and loud when broken. I treated the study as finished at the readout. It was not finished, it was testable, and I let that go.

Thank you

Happy to go deeper on the session design, the two analyses, the weighted score, or the four ties.



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